INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

Revision Notes

2.1 DO NOT GAMBLE: RUSSIA-UKRAINE CONFLICT

Context

- Spillover risk: long-range attacks and gray-zone ops may hit North Atlantic Treaty Organization; diplomacy needed.

Rising Risk of Escalation

- North Atlantic Treaty Organization incidents: Poland, Romania, Germany.
- Gray-zone: sabotage, cyberattacks, espionage, covert recruitment; tests North Atlantic Treaty Organization.
- Rhetoric: threats beyond Ukraine; regime change hint for Kyiv.

Russia's Strategic Dilemma

- Slow gains: holds more than 20% of Ukraine's pre-2014 territory.
- Ukraine's strikes: energy, supply, military targets; about 20% refining capacity hit.
- European aid sustains Ukraine.

Dangerous Stalemate

- No victor; costs pressure Russian leadership.
- Miscalculation: Russia may exploit Western distraction; attack on North Atlantic Treaty Organization = nuclear-power clash.

Why Escalation is Risky

- Regional war → European war; nuclear risk; hits energy security, recovery, global food and energy.

Way Forward

- Negotiate with Ukraine and West; mechanisms to stop North Atlantic Treaty Organization-incident escalation.
- Confidence-building: ceasefire, communication channels, security guarantees.
- Diplomacy, not expansion; strengthen multilateral platforms.

2.2 INDIA MUST CATCH UP IN CHINA-UNITED STATES TECH RACE

Context

- Race is about science-industry ecosystem (Artificial Intelligence, research, manufacturing, finance, supply chains); India needs reform and private investment.

China's Science-Industry Strategy

- Artificial Intelligence integration: robotics, automobiles, biotech, materials, energy, agriculture, research.
- Path: technology absorption → manufacturing dominance → original research.
- Research and Development: 2.8% of Gross Domestic Product (2025); basic research up 11%.

United States Strategy: Reconnecting Science with Manufacturing

- Strong: universities, labs, tech firms, capital markets; weak: offshored manufacturing, supply-chain risk.

- Reset: link discovery to domestic manufacturing; Artificial Intelligence as accelerator.

The Emerging China-United States Model

- China: manufacturing → research; United States: science → manufacturing.
- Real race is the ecosystem (universities and labs, entrepreneurs and finance, energy and factories, supply chains and markets), not one Artificial Intelligence model or humanoid robot.

India's Major Gaps

- Research and Development: India 0.64% versus China 2.8% versus United States 3.5% of Gross Domestic Product.
- Weak private investment; poor science-industry links.
- 1990s reforms skipped scientific institutions; bureaucracy; talent retention.

India's Existing Initiatives

- Artificial Intelligence; semiconductors; quantum; draft robotics policy.

Need for a Strategic Shift

- Autonomy for science bodies; long-term private capital.
- Self-reliance is not the same as isolation; bring researchers back.
- Link institutions, startups, industry, markets.

Way Forward

- Raise public and private Research and Development; industry-led deep tech.
- Autonomy, merit funding, less bureaucracy.
- Global collaboration plus self-reliance; mission-oriented innovation.

2.3 INDUS WATERS TREATY AND THE HAGUE ARBITRATION

Context

- Indus Waters Treaty, 1960 strained: tensions, hydropower disputes, parallel arbitration, terrorism, climate.

Indus Waters Treaty, 1960

- World Bank-mediated.
- Eastern (Ravi, Beas, Sutlej) → India; Western (Indus, Jhelum, Chenab) → Pakistan.
- India: limited western use (domestic, agriculture, hydropower, run-of-the-river).

Run-of-the-River Projects

- Power from natural flow; no large storage.
- Kishanganga: 330 megawatts (Jhelum tributary); Ratle: 850 megawatts (Chenab).

Pakistan's Concerns

- Alleges excess pondage, letting India control flows = violation.
- Heavy Indus dependence.

Dispute-Resolution Mechanism

- Permanent Indus Commission: routine issues; Neutral Expert: technical (design); Court of Arbitration: legal.

Parallel Arbitration Controversy

- Pakistan bypassed Neutral Expert; India: technical dispute.
- World Bank paused both in 2016; revived 2022.
- Jurisdiction and conflicting-decision concerns.

Post-Pahalgam Tensions

- April 2025 attack → India put treaty in abeyance until terrorism ends.
- Permanent Court of Arbitration: treaty still in force; India rejects Permanent Court of Arbitration jurisdiction, did not participate.

Emerging Challenges

- Procedural uncertainty; terror-water linkage deepens mistrust.
- Hurts India's hydropower goals; Pakistan highly vulnerable.
- Climate: glacier melt, rainfall change, extremes.

Way Forward

- Strengthen Permanent Indus Commission; clarify roles of three bodies.
- Firmness plus dialogue; climate-resilient management.
- Cooperate on floods, hydrological data, disaster resilience; keep water diplomacy open.

2.4 FORGING CONSENSUS: INDIA AND THE SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION MEETING

Context

- 2026 Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit, Bishkek: India needs deeper Eurasian engagement.

Key Outcomes of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit

- India: dismantle terror financing, recruitment, radicalisation, safe havens; no double standards.
- Bishkek Declaration: condemned all terrorism including cross-border; condemned United States-Israel attacks on Iran; backed Iran's peaceful nuclear rights under Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons.
- Strain: United States tariffs, Russia sanctions, Iran conflict, Hormuz disruption.
- Central Asia: revive trade, critical minerals, tourism, connectivity.
- BRICS overlap helps consensus before New Delhi BRICS Summit.
- Pakistan chairs Shanghai Cooperation Organisation: keep terrorism, security, connectivity on agenda.

Significance of Shanghai Cooperation Organisation for India

- Autonomy: engage Russia, China, Iran, Central Asia together.
- Central Asia trade, energy, critical minerals; complements International North-South Transport Corridor.
- Counter-terrorism platform; energy diversification; balance despite China-Pakistan differences.

Challenges for India

- India-Pakistan tensions; China's Central Asia influence.
- United States-Russia-China-Iran rivalries block consensus.
- No direct land access; low trade and investment.

Way Forward

- Use Shanghai Cooperation Organisation with BRICS, Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation, Association of Southeast Asian Nations-led forums.
- Central Asia: critical minerals, pharma, IT, education, tourism; speed Chabahar and International North-South Transport Corridor.
- Institutionalise counter-terrorism; issue-based cooperation; no exclusive bloc.

2.5 THE GULF IS CALLING AND NEW DELHI MUST LISTEN

Context

- New defence partnerships and maritime threats: India must move beyond economic and diaspora ties to security ties.

Changing Nature of India-West Asia Engagement

- Old: oil, jobs, remittances, trade; multi-alignment (Saudi Arabia, Iran, Israel, United Arab Emirates), no security commitments.
- Now: instability and doubt on United States commitment → Gulf diversifies partners.
- Makkah defence agreement: Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, Pakistan.

Why West Asia Matters for India

- Crude and gas; Indian Ocean-Red Sea-Gulf trade routes; Indian diaspora and remittances.
- Chokepoints: Hormuz, Bab-el-Mandeb, Gulf of Aden; Gulf investment.

Emerging Security Challenges

- Red Sea, Gulf of Aden, Hormuz instability; chokepoint shocks.
- Cheap drones threaten ports, energy, logistics.
- Iran, Yemen, Sudan conflicts spill over; new alignments shift western maritime balance.

Significance of Makkah Joint Defence Agreement

- Collective defence; Strategic Political and Defence Committee, permanent secretariat.
- Pakistan: wider Gulf role; Türkiye: military and defence-industry strength; Gulf diversifying.

India's Existing Security Engagement

Country	Engagement
United Arab Emirates	Defence, maritime security, intelligence, training, technology.
Saudi Arabia	Exchanges, training, maritime cooperation.
Other / broader approach	Information sharing, exercises, joint production; minilateral ties (United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Israel), no rigid alliances.

Why India Needs a Strategic Shift

- Economic → security partner; presence → capability (surveillance, reach, interoperability).
- Procurement → co-production; bilateral → minilateral; reactive → proactive.

What India Should Focus On

- Naval cooperation: Hormuz, Gulf of Oman, Gulf of Aden, western Indian Ocean.
- Maritime awareness, counter-terrorism, counter-drone intelligence; refuelling and repair access.
- Offer missiles, drones, sensors, naval systems; realistic exercises; protect ports, energy sites, undersea infrastructure, corridors.

Challenges for India

- Alliance entrapment; Iran-Gulf and Israel-Arab balancing; resource costs; avoid single-bloc dependence.

Way Forward

- Joint patrols, surveillance, exercises, production, research; secure western Indian Ocean.
- Flexible ties with United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Oman; engage Gulf, Iran, Israel together.
- Hard plus soft power (navy, diplomacy, trade, diaspora, development); no rigid alliances.

2.6 UNITED STATES TARIFFS ARE NOT WHAT IS HOLDING BACK INDIAN RESEARCH

Context

- Real constraint is weak private Research and Development, not tariffs.

Tariff Exposure and Research Mismatch

- Exposed, low-Research and Development sectors: chemicals, plastics, metals, machinery, auto components, leather.
- Metals: about 0.4% of sales versus 1.6% global; autos, electrical: far below global about 5%.
- Research concentrated in pharma, automobiles.

Tariffs Are Not the Root Cause

- No break in patents or Research and Development after tariffs; weakness predates disputes.
- Firms prefer cheap standard products; research needs large markets.

Where Tariffs Pose a Real Research Risk

- Pharma: research-heavy; exempted.
- Autos: 25% United States duty on auto parts; metal tariffs raise input costs; real threat is autos.

India's Structural Research and Development Deficit

- Low Gross Domestic Product share; weak industry share; mostly routine development and testing.
- Nvidia alone spends nearly as much as all Indian industry.

Research, Development and Innovation Scheme and Its Limitations

- 1 Lakh Crore rupees; long-term, low-cost capital; 6 years; Artificial Intelligence, semiconductors, quantum, biotech.
- Gap: chemicals, auto components; link support to real research, not protection.

Turning Trade Pressure into Innovation

- Move up value chain; fund core research; tie tariff relief to Research and Development; faster firm-level data.

Way Forward

- Long-term finance, incentives, public-private partnerships; broaden Research and Development (chemicals, engineering, electronics, auto).
- Protection must drive upgrading; track Research and Development, patents, exports; high-value manufacturing.

2.7 NATURAL PARTNERS: INDIA-BELGIUM TIES

Context

- Belgian Prime Minister's visit; Europe outreach ahead of India-European Union Free Trade Agreement.

Strengthening Economic Partnership

- Trade about 13 billion United States dollars; about 1/3 diamonds (Antwerp hub; Mumbai, Surat cut and polish).
- Free Trade Agreement → renewables, food processing; target: double trade in 5 years.

Expanding Defence Cooperation

- Belgium: small arms, drones, counter-drone, ammunition, naval defence.

- Memorandum of Understanding on co-development; Letter of Intent; resident Defence Attaché in Brussels.
- India diversifies suppliers.

India-European Union Strategic Convergence

- Belgium understands India's concern on overdependence (especially China).
- Shared democracy, markets, people ties; resilient supply chains.

Geopolitical Significance

- Wider India-Europe partnership; ties hold despite differences on Russia-Ukraine; strategic maturity.

Opportunities for India

- European defence technology; market diversification; investment (renewables, food processing, advanced manufacturing); Free Trade Agreement framework.

Way Forward

- Conclude Free Trade Agreement; shift to joint Research and Development, manufacturing, technology transfer.
- Diversify beyond diamonds; issue-based ties with Russia, China; institutionalise engagement.

2.8 INDIA-JAPAN DEFENCE COOPERATION BREAKS NEW GROUND

Context

- August 2026: Japan's Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi visits; shift from convergence to operational capability.

Evolution of India-Japan Strategic Partnership

- 2007: Shinzo Abe's "Confluence of the Two Seas" speech in Indian Parliament → Indo-Pacific concept.
- Shared concerns: status-quo change, coercion, militarisation, navigation freedom.
- Tools: defence dialogues, 2+2, logistics pacts, exercises, equipment-transfer framework.

From Strategic Convergence to Operational Capability

- Declarations need usable capability; Koizumi visit targets interoperability, information sharing, industry ties; judged on delivery.

Maritime Domain Awareness

- Maritime Domain Awareness: sea awareness via ships, satellites, radars, networks.
- Japan (East China Sea, Western Pacific) + India (Indian Ocean) = continuous picture; better surveillance, interoperability.

Defence-Industrial Cooperation

- Joint naval shipbuilding and design; Japan's technology + India's production (Make in India).
- Reciprocal ship-repair access; fills political-industrial gap.

UNICORN and Technology Transfer

- UNICORN: integrated communications antenna mast; cuts radar cross-section.
- Not new: November 2024 Memorandum of Understanding with Bharat Electronics Limited; Japan's first defence equipment transfer to India.
- Defence Research and Development Organisation + Japan's Acquisition, Technology and Logistics Agency; 2015 transfer agreement was slow: delivery matters.

Growing Military Interoperability

- Veer Guardian 2026: Japanese fighters first time in India; 9-22 September 2026.
- Unmanned systems, short-notice drills, special forces; Japan eyes India's integrated theatre commands.

Expanding Maritime Geography

- Koizumi visited Western Naval Command, Indian Naval Ship Chennai (Mumbai): beyond Bay of Bengal and Malacca.
- Arabian Sea and western Indian Ocean: energy, sea lanes; India as net security provider.

Beyond a China-Centric Partnership

- China's expansion drives ties, but agenda includes maritime security, supply chains, defence industry, logistics, critical technologies, third-country cooperation.
- Aim: rules-based Indo-Pacific, not anti-China bloc.

Wider Strategic Significance

- July 2026 Annual Summit: economic security, critical technologies, supply chains.
- Japan's technology + India's industry → resilience, autonomy.

Way Forward

- Time-bound projects; joint production, technology transfer.
- Stronger Maritime Domain Awareness; bigger exercises; third-country partners; not exclusively China-centric.

2.9 DANGEROUS PHASE: CRISIS IN WEST ASIA

Context

- United States-Iran conflict widening: Iran, United States forces, Jordan, Saudi Arabia, Houthis; Hormuz and Red Sea at risk.

Multi-Front Escalation

- United States hit 5 Iranian oil tankers; Iran struck Muwaffaq Salti base (Jordan) with ballistic missiles.
- Iran: restricted zone in Hormuz; warns ships under United States escort.
- Houthis (Iran-aligned) attacked Saudi Arabia; spread to Jordan, Red Sea, Bab-el-Mandeb.

Strategic Maritime Chokepoints at Risk

- Hormuz: Persian Gulf-Gulf of Oman; oil. Red Sea: Europe-Asia corridor. Bab-el-Mandeb: Red Sea-Gulf of Aden, exposed to Yemen.
- Simultaneous instability → wider maritime crisis.

Energy and Global Economic Risks

- Higher crude prices; freight, insurance, transport costs; Europe-Asia supply chains; global inflation.

Why the Conflict Is Becoming More Dangerous

- United States: strikes plus economic pressure; Iran keeps missile and retaliation capacity.
- Proxies widen war; tit-for-tat shrinks space for talks.

Implications for India

- Import-dependent crude; shipping time and cost; exports, remittances, connectivity.
- Diaspora: evacuation concern; balance United States, Iran, Gulf, Israel.

Way Forward

- Diplomatic de-escalation; safe-shipping cooperation.
- Diversify crude suppliers, strategic petroleum reserves, renewables; contingency plans for diaspora and trade.

2.10 A UNILATERAL AMERICA IN A POST-UNIPOLAR WORLD

Context

- 25 years after 9/11: United States top military power but overreached; China's rise, Russia's assertiveness → multipolar order.

From Counter-Terrorism to Regime Change

- Afghanistan: al-Qaeda, Taliban → state-building, regime change.
- Iraq, 2003: diverted focus; Taliban regrouped; al-Qaeda in Iraq → Islamic State of Iraq and Syria.
- Libya, 2011: North Atlantic Treaty Organization toppled Qaddafi; fragmentation, militias, terror in Sahel.
- Iran's rise: Saddam's fall removed buffer.

Strategic Overreach and Its Costs

- 2021 Afghan withdrawal (refocus on China) read as weakness; Russia invaded Ukraine 2022.
- Israel-Palestine and Iran confrontation limit repositioning; terror groups dispersed, adapted.

Emergence of a Post-Unipolar Order

- China = second pole; Russia challenges United States-led European security.
- Allies resent transactional United States policy; interventions eroded unipolar freedom.

The Unilateralism Paradox

- Unilateral military solutions despite diffused power; Israel dependence pulls United States into conflicts.
- Dilemma: security provider versus overreach.

Implications for India

- Issue-based partnerships; engage United States, Russia, China, Europe, West Asia, Global South.
- Oil prices, routes, supply risks; push representative, rules-based, multipolar order.

2.11 THE BRICS BANK: AN ALTERNATIVE THAT WASN'T

Context

- BRICS built New Development Bank and Contingent Reserve Arrangement to cut Western dependence but still rely on the existing system.

BRICS' Vision of Financial Reform

Body	Role
BRICS institutions (overall)	Alternatives to World Bank, International Monetary Fund; more voice for developing economies.
New Development Bank	2015; infrastructure; local currencies.
Contingent Reserve Arrangement	100 billion United States dollars pool; balance-of-payments safety net; less International Monetary Fund reliance.

Body	Role
De-dollarisation	Local-currency settlement.

New Development Bank: Gap Between Vision and Reality

- Many bonds in United States dollars (yuan also major).
- Local-currency lending: target 30% by end-2025 missed; about 22% by mid-2025.
- Relies on Western rating agencies and norms; about 39 billion United States dollars approved by end-2024, far below World Bank.

Contingent Reserve Arrangement: An Incomplete Alternative to International Monetary Fund

- Not activated in first decade; access above 30% needs International Monetary Fund programme; no permanent staff or research.

De-Dollarisation: Rhetoric versus Reality

- No common currency or roadmap; India cautious, China pushes yuan.
- Dollar dominant in trade, reserves, finance; differences block unified challenge.

International Monetary Fund Reform and BRICS' Approach

- Wants quota-based, resourced International Monetary Fund (reform, not replace).
- United States: about 16.49% votes; decisions need 85% → United States veto.
- More quota alone won't change the architecture.

Way Forward

- Real local-currency lending; deeper BRICS markets; stronger Contingent Reserve Arrangement.
- Interoperable payments; International Monetary Fund quota reform; better coordination.

2.12 PAKISTAN'S WESTWARD TURN: STRATEGIC DEPTH OR OVERSTRETCH

Context

- Ties with Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, West Asia: depth and leverage, but overstretch risk.

Strategic Depth and Strategic Overstretch

- Depth: extra geographic, political, military, diplomatic space.
- Pakistan seeks it in Afghanistan, West Asia versus India.
- Overstretch: commitments beyond resources; Paul Kennedy, The Rise and Fall of the Great Powers.

Pakistan's Westward Strategic Shift

- Cold War: United States and West; after 1971 dismemberment: Islamic identity, West Asia.
- Saudi Arabia: finance; Türkiye: defence technology; Iran: neighbour, balance; United States: interlocutor.

Makkah Joint Defence Agreement

- Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye: attack on one = attack on all.
- Institutionalised; military technology, defence production; more visibility for Pakistan.

Strategic Benefits for Pakistan

- Saudi finance; Türkiye drones and defence manufacturing; Pakistan's manpower and nuclear deterrence.

- Leverage in Muslim world; options against India.

Risks of Strategic Overstretch

- Iran-Saudi divergence; Saudi-Houthi clash forces choices.
- Resources diverted from India; weak economy.
- Balancing Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, Iran, China, United States; alliance trap.

Implications for India

- Pakistan gets finance and defence resources; Türkiye-Pakistan ties a concern.
- Opportunity: dilutes Pakistan's India focus.
- India's Gulf trade, investment, energy ties stabilise; balance Saudi, United Arab Emirates, Iran, Israel.

Way Forward

- Deepen Gulf ties (trade, investment, energy, defence); protect Chabahar.
- Arabian Sea, Gulf of Aden, Red Sea cooperation.
- Avoid blocs; monitor Pakistan's commitments; be indispensable in Gulf networks.

2.13 THE MULTIPOLAR WORLD INDIA WANTS MAY BE A DISTANT REALITY

Context

- United States-China rivalry complicates smooth shift to multipolarity.

Multipolarity and the Changing World Order

- Multipolarity: many power centres (versus bipolarity: two).
- India wants reformed multipolar order for middle and emerging powers.
- Raja Mohan: BRICS, Group of Twenty, Group of Seven, Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation limited by great-power rivalry.
- Power = economy, technology, capital, energy, supply-chain control.

The Emerging Group of Two Dynamic

- United States-China axis in trade, technology, finance, security; interdependence restrains conflict.
- Thucydides Trap: rising versus established power; war not inevitable.
- Obstacles: Taiwan, tech curbs, trade imbalance, security rivalry.

Russia and the Possibility of a Group of Three

- Russia: military, reach, energy; United States-Russia deal could shift Europe-Ukraine-Eurasia balance.
- Russia's China dependence affects India-Russia ties.
- Result: overlapping Group of Two, Group of Three, coalitions.

Limits of Multilateral Institutions

- BRICS: expanded, divergent interests; Group of Twenty: United States-China disagreement blocks consensus.
- Rivalry paralyses institutions; India should use them as tools, not as foundation.

Implications for India

- Engage United States, China, Russia, Europe, Japan, West Asia, Global South; diversify options.
- China: competition, dialogue, risk management; BRICS: Global South and reform, not a balancer.

Way Forward

- Pragmatic multilateralism; issue coalitions (technology, critical minerals, maritime security, climate, connectivity, supply chains).
- Diversify; push United Nations Security Council reform; build economic, technology, military, manufacturing capability.

2.14 CURRENCY CONUNDRUM: BRICS NEW DELHI DECLARATION

Context

- Local-currency trade and de-dollarisation rising; common currency hindered by economic differences, convertibility, imbalances, China's weight.

Local-Currency Trade versus Common Currency

Type	Meaning
Local-currency trade	National currencies, no third currency like dollar.
Common currency	Single currency like euro; needs deep integration.
De-dollarisation	Less dollar use; not necessarily a BRICS currency.

Why a BRICS Common Currency Faces Challenges

- Trade imbalances build one-sided balances.
- Rupee accumulation: partners can't spend rupees on Indian goods and services.
- Needs exchange-rate management, liquidity, settlement, coordination; members differ in inflation, monetary policy, exchange regimes, capital controls, markets.

India's Currency Dilemma

- Weaker rupee: exporters gain; importers (crude, gold) lose.
- Dollar embedded in trade, finance, pricing, reserves; diversify payments without new single dependence.

China Factor in BRICS

- Huge BRICS share; yuan could dominate payments → swaps one dependence for another.
- India-China strategic and border differences; India backs local currencies, cautious on one currency.

BRICS and the Dollar-Centric System

- Payments, banking, markets, commodities tied to dollar; network effects.
- Gradual path: local settlement, payment interoperability, alternative channels.

Way Forward

- Local settlement where trade is balanced; better payment systems and messaging.
- Diversify exports to recycle balances; diversify currencies; gradual, no immediate monetary union.

2.15 MISREADING THE 1951 REFUGEE CONVENTION IN INDIA'S CONTEXT

Context

- 75 years of Convention; non-refoulement, Rohingya; India lacks comprehensive refugee law.

Refugee versus Migrant

Term	Meaning
Refugee	Outside country, well-founded fear of persecution.
Migrant	Moves for work, education, family, better life; overlaps possible.

- Refugee = protection from persecution and forced return; for example, Tibetans after 1959.

1951 Convention and 1967 Protocol

- 1951: United Nations refugee standards; original geographical and temporal limits.
- 1967 Protocol: removed limits.
- India: not a party to either.

Principle of Non-Refoulement

- No return to where life or freedom is threatened; foundational.
- Debate: customary-law status, application to non-parties; key in deportation cases.

Why India Has Not Joined the Convention

- Porous borders, identity verification; large population, own needs.
- Policy discretion; no refugee statute (existing laws, executive policy).

India's Refugee Experience

- Dalai Lama and Tibetans; 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War influx.
- Sri Lanka, Afghanistan, Myanmar; case-specific policy.

Constitutional and Judicial Dimensions

- Articles 14, 21 apply broadly; scope for foreigners and deportation fact-dependent.
- Courts use treaties as interpretive aids; treaty-making by Executive and Parliament.
- Rohingya cases: security versus forced-return protection.

Way Forward

- Transparent national framework (status, screening, documentation, appeals).
- Security screening plus protection; constitutional consistency.
- Regional cooperation (documentation, voluntary return, resettlement); analyse non-refoulement carefully.

2.16 A WAR ROOM FOR INDIA IN AN AGE OF SANCTIONS

Context

- Rising secondary sanctions and controls: India needs capacity to manage coercion.

Primary versus Secondary Sanctions

Type	Meaning
Primary	A state directly restricts a target under its law.
Secondary	Penalises third-country entities dealing with target.

- Extraterritorial reach; hits banking, shipping, insurance, energy, technology, trade.

Weaponised Interdependence

- By Henry Farrell, Abraham Newman: states exploit control of financial, technology, logistics, information networks.

- Dollar-based payments raise exposure; interdependence = opportunity plus vulnerability.

Why Sanctions Matter for India

- Payments and bank access; oil, gas, petroleum, shipping costs; vessel financing, insurance, routes.
- Firms uncertain even if legal in India.

Institutional Fragmentation in India

- Ministries: Ministry of External Affairs, Finance, Reserve Bank of India, Commerce and Industry, Petroleum and Natural Gas, Ports, Shipping and Waterways.
- One sanction hits many sectors; coordination gap; needs whole-of-government approach.

Lessons from International Experience

- European Union blocking statutes shield from extraterritorial effects.
- Law alone fails: dependence on banks and payment networks forces compliance; need preparedness plus less dependence.

Building India's Sanctions Resilience

- Central mechanism; real-time tracking (payments, insurance, shipping, commodities, supply chains).
- Legal analysis, exemption talks, regulatory clarity, early warnings.
- Reserves and alternatives: crude, Liquefied Petroleum Gas, fertilisers; build shipping, insurance, payment capacity.

India's Strategic Approach

- United Nations Security Council sanctions is not the same as unilateral sanctions.
- Autonomy; diversify suppliers, payments, currencies; larger economy = bargaining space.

Way Forward

- Economic Security and Sanctions Cell; real-time dependency database (energy, finance, shipping, technology, trade).
- Avoid single supplier, route, currency, network; indigenous maritime insurance and shipping.
- More reserves, alternative logistics; partner on payment, trade, supply-chain resilience.

2.17 A MALACCA-SINGAPORE MODEL FOR RESOLVING HORMUZ

Context

- Hormuz tensions: Malacca model offered to balance coastal security and free navigation.

Understanding Maritime Straits

- Narrow passage linking water bodies; chokepoint; disruption hits trade, energy, connectivity.

Territorial Waters under United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea

- United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea: territorial sea up to 12 nautical miles; coastal sovereignty subject to international law.
- Strait under 24 nautical miles wide: territorial seas meet → reconcile sovereignty and navigation.

Strategic Importance of the Malacca Strait

- Between Malay Peninsula and Sumatra; links Andaman Sea and Strait of Singapore.
- Major trade route; Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore stakeholders.

Evolution of the Malacca Strait Arrangement

- Sukarno's Indonesia sought control of inter-island waters; Indonesia, Malaysia asserted territorial rights; Singapore wanted a secure, navigable strait.
- 1971: common position; cooperation balanced sovereignty and navigation.

Innocent Passage and Transit Passage

Passage	Meaning
Innocent passage	Through territorial sea, lawful conditions.
Transit passage	Broader, continuous and expeditious through international straits; matters for warships, submarines.

- Balances sovereignty and navigation freedom.

Cooperative Maritime Governance

- Hydrographic surveys, lighthouses, navigation markers; Vessel Traffic Services.
- Oil-spill response, ecological protection, pollution monitoring; voluntary funding, not toll-tax.

Strategic Importance of the Strait of Hormuz

- Between Iran and Oman; key for oil and energy; regional economies need uninterrupted passage.

Legal and Security Disagreements

- Iran hasn't ratified United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea; says warships need its permission; United States rejects.
- Coastal authority versus navigation freedom; tied to regional security and nuclear concerns.

Possibility of a Malacca-Type Framework

- Address coastal security while keeping passage open, safe, predictable.
- Energy-dependent states back it; Qatar supports Malacca-inspired approach.

Limitations of Direct Replication

- More complex environment; nuclear concerns; Iran-United States tensions.
- Malacca = reference model, not template.

Way Forward

- Confidence-building; navigation systems, information sharing, emergency response, pollution control.
- Producer-consumer cooperation; legal dialogue on navigation, coastal security, maritime law; context-specific design.

2.18 UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL PERMANENT MEMBERSHIP AND VETO POWERS

Context

- 22 September 2026, United Nations General Assembly: Emmanuel Macron proposed voluntary veto restraint in genocide, crimes against humanity, mass atrocities.

Background

- United Nations Security Council: 15 members (5 permanent + 10 non-permanent).
- One permanent-member veto blocks substantive resolutions.
- Veto from 1945: keep major powers in, avoid League of Nations failure.
- Institutions balance collective and major-power interests.

Failure Of Veto And Global Paralysis

- Privilege versus responsibility.
- Syria: Russia, China vetoed 2014 International Criminal Court referral despite 13 votes in favour.
- Major-power divisions → gridlock.

Permanent Member Factions And Veto Reform Initiatives

Group / Initiative	Details
Permanent member factions	Reformers: France, United Kingdom; Traditionals: United States, Russia, China.
France-Mexico (2015)	Voluntary no-veto in mass atrocities; 128 countries; United Kingdom endorsed.
Liechtenstein (April 2022)	Vetoing permanent member explains to 193-member United Nations General Assembly within 10 working days.
Accountability, Coherence and Transparency Code of Conduct	All 15 members avoid voting against credible atrocity-prevention action.

Challenges To Veto Reform In The United Nations Security Council

- Article 108: Charter amendment needs two-thirds United Nations General Assembly plus two-thirds ratification including all Permanent Five.
- Realpolitik; voluntary, non-binding reforms.
- Thucydides: "The strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must."

2.19 KASHMIR AS INDIA'S GATEWAY TO EURASIAN OPPORTUNITY

Context

- View Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh as economic gateways to Central Asia and Eurasia, not just security; subject to diplomatic and security conditions.

Demographic Dividend and Aspiration-Reality Gap

- Dividend needs education, skills, jobs.
- Smartphones raised aspirations faster than jobs → frustration.
- Jammu and Kashmir youth: same aspirations plus conflict burden.

Kashmir's Historical Connectivity

- Crossroads of South Asia, Central Asia, Tibet; goods, people, ideas, culture, philosophy, literature, skills.
- Mir Sayyid Ali Hamadani: Persian, Central Asian craftsmen shaped handicrafts.
- Connectivity builds ecosystems.

Why Eurasian Connectivity Matters

- Market access; jobs (construction, logistics, warehousing, tourism, agriculture, manufacturing, services).
- Land corridors spread growth along route; complements Chabahar and International North-South Transport Corridor.

Strategic and Diplomatic Challenges

- Pakistan: western routes need suitable conditions; China: sensitive borders.
- Connectivity can't replace security, but opens channels; phased pilot corridors.

Existing Connectivity Foundations

- Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link; Chenab Rail Bridge (2025).
- Chabahar-International North-South Transport Corridor to Central Asia, Russia via Iran.
- Pair transport with logistics, production, tourism, services.

Way Forward

- Phased strategy by security, diplomacy, viability; Confidence-Building Measures.
- Link roads and rail to logistics parks, warehouses, tourism, clusters; skills, entrepreneurship, jobs.
- Keep border management, customs, counter-terrorism safeguards.

2.20 NEW EQUILIBRIUM: RECALIBRATION OF UNITED STATES-CHINA TIES

Context

- September 2026: Chinese President in Washington; stabilising ties despite rivalry (technology, trade, Taiwan, strategic resources).

From Thucydides Trap to Competitive Coexistence

- Thucydides Trap: rising versus established power conflict risk.
- Rivalry coexists with interdependence and selective cooperation: competition, negotiation, risk management.

Why Both Sides Seek Stability

- Deep trade, investment, supply-chain links.
- Visit operationalised United States-China Boards of Trade and Investment; tariff treatment for 30 billion United States dollars non-sensitive goods each way (White House).
- Leader talks avert escalation; instability hits global economy.

Areas of Continuing Competition

- Semiconductors: United States edge versus China self-reliance; rare earths: China central.
- Taiwan: major fault line; Artificial Intelligence: competition plus dialogue on risks.

The New Equilibrium

- Managed rivalry: neither cooperation nor decoupling.
- Issue-based cooperation; regular leader communication; economic pragmatism.

Implications for India

- China+1 opportunity; but stabilisation won't automatically widen India's space.
- Autonomy, multi-alignment, own capabilities (semiconductors, critical minerals, electronics, defence, advanced technology).
- United States, Japan, Australia, Europe partnerships alongside broader diplomacy.

Way Forward for India

- Rise on own capability: infrastructure, skills, logistics, ease of doing business.
- Technology sovereignty (Artificial Intelligence, semiconductors, telecom); diversified partnerships.
- Back multilateralism; prepare for both rivalry and stabilisation.

2.21 THE GHOSTS OF 1945 AND TODAY'S CONTEST OVER ASIA

Context

- September 2026 United States-China summit revived shared World War II narrative amid rivalry (technology, Taiwan, influence, resources); history shapes geopolitics.

World War II and the Post-War Order

- United States and China recalled being Allies; World War II created post-war institutions; shared history builds legitimacy.

Yalta System and Russian Strategic Narrative

- Yalta, 1945: Roosevelt, Churchill, Stalin; post-war settlement.
- Western and Soviet spheres emerged; "two fixed zones" is misleading.
- Russia cites its role defeating Nazi Germany for European security claims.

San Francisco System and East Asia

- 1951 San Francisco Peace Treaty: ended war with Japan; East Asian security base.
- United States-Japan alliance central; China sees United States alliance network as balance factor, wants more influence.

China's Changing World War II Narrative

- World War II China = Republic of China (Chiang Kai-shek); People's Republic of China founded 1949: "People's Republic of China fought with United States" needs qualification.
- Chinese Communist Party narrative: limited (Mao era) → victimhood → victory against fascism; supports claim to larger role.

Japan and the Politics of Historical Memory

- Axis power → key United States partner; defence normalisation versus pacifist framework; competing histories (China, Japan, South Korea).
- Enemy State Clauses: United Nations Charter Articles 53, 77, 107; United Nations General Assembly declared obsolete 1995; not deleted.

India and the World War II Legacy

- 2.5 million soldiers: largest volunteer army; North Africa, Europe, Southeast Asia.
- Major role in Burma versus Imperial Japan; diplomatic asset for India's global-governance stake.

Implications for India

- Changing Indo-Pacific; strategic autonomy; World War II history as narrative.
- United States, Japan, Australia, Europe partnerships alongside China engagement.

Way Forward

- Use history carefully; avoid single-power dependence.
- Maritime security, connectivity, technology, supply chains; indigenous defence and critical technology; rules-based order.

2.22 THE UNITED NATIONS' LONG ROAD TO RESTORING TRUST

Context

- 81st United Nations General Assembly theme: "Restoring Trust, Managing Transformation: A United Nations That Delivers for All"; effectiveness, representation, legitimacy concerns.

Why the United Nations Matters

- Founded 1945 after World War II; permanent dialogue platform; built international law, humanitarian norms, human rights mechanisms; predictability.

Why Trust in the United Nations Has Come Under Pressure

- United Nations Security Council: 15 members, 5 vetoes; deadlock; veto blocks crisis action.
- General Assembly Resolution 76/262 (2022): United Nations General Assembly meets within 10 working days after a veto.
- Council doesn't reflect today's population, economy, geopolitics.

Governance and Accountability Challenges

- Oversight deficit (procurement, administration).
- Peacekeeper sexual exploitation and abuse; United Nations strengthened reporting, investigation, discipline.
- Weak mission procurement controls → risk-based auditing; legitimacy needs enforcement, transparency.

Financial and Political Constraints

- Dependence on member contributions; donor influence; slow, risk-averse bureaucracy.
- Balance state control, accountability, effectiveness.

Global South and Representation

- Developing countries = majority of members, large population share; limited United Nations Security Council voice.
- India, Brazil, African states seek reform; more legitimacy.

United Nations's Continuing Contributions

- Humanitarian aid (food, health, refugees); peacekeeping (conflict management, civilian protection, stabilisation).
- Coordination: climate, development, health, humanitarian affairs, emerging technologies; still vital.

Way Forward

- Reform United Nations Security Council (Africa, Asia, Latin America); veto transparency.
- Stronger oversight (auditing, procurement, whistle-blower protection); more Global South in leadership and staffing.
- Decentralise peacebuilding (regional organisations, local institutions, civil society).
- Rebuild trust: transparency, accountability, equal application of law, measurable results (stressed by 81st United Nations General Assembly President).